

Grammar - Question Tags

1. INTRODUCTION TO QUESTION TAGS

A **Question Tag** is a short question added to the end of a statement.

It is used to:

- confirm information,
- seek agreement,
- continue the conversation politely.

Examples

- You are coming, **aren't you?**
- She can swim, **can't she?**
- They went home, **didn't they?**

Simple Definition: "Question Tag = Statement + Mini Question"

MAIN PURPOSE OF QUESTION TAGS

Purpose	Example
Confirmation	It is hot today, isn't it?
Agreement	You know him, don't you?
Polite conversation	We should help them, shouldn't we?

MEMORY TRICK: "Half statement + Half question"

2. TYPES OF SENTENCES USED IN QUESTION TAGS

Question tags are mainly attached to:

1. Statement Sentences
2. Imperative Sentences
3. Suggestions/Requests

(A) STATEMENT SENTENCES

These are ordinary statements.

Examples

- She is happy, isn't she?
- They play cricket, don't they?

(B) IMPERATIVE SENTENCES

Imperative sentences:

- give orders,
- requests,
- advice,
- suggestions.

Examples

- Open the door, will you?

- Don't make noise, will you?
- Kindly help me, would you?

Important Rule

Imperative sentences usually take:

- will you?
- won't you?
- would you?

(C) LET'S SENTENCES

"Let's" expresses a suggestion.

Example

- Let's go outside, shall we?

MEMORY TRICK: "Let's → shall we?"

3. POSITIVE STATEMENT

A positive statement does NOT contain:

- not
- never
- no
- nobody
- nothing

Examples

Positive Statement	Question Tag
He is a doctor,	isn't he?
She can dance,	can't she?
They went home,	didn't they?

MEMORY TRICK: "Positive goes Negative"

4. NEGATIVE STATEMENT

Negative statements contain:

- not,
 - never,
 - no,
 - nobody,
 - hardly,
 - scarcely,
 - rarely,
 - seldom etc.
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Examples

Negative Statement	Question Tag
She isn't ready,	is she?
They don't know,	do they?
He never comes late,	does he?

MEMORY TRICK: "Negative becomes Positive"

MASTER RULE OF QUESTION TAGS

Statement	Tag
Positive	Negative
Negative	Positive

5. AUXILIARY / HELPING VERBS

Question tags are formed using: **Auxiliary / Helping Verbs**

The same auxiliary used in the statement is usually repeated in the tag.

COMMON AUXILIARY VERBS

Auxiliary	Example
is	She is ready, isn't she?
are	They are students, aren't they?
was	He was late, wasn't he?
have	You have finished, haven't you?
can	She can sing, can't she?
will	He will come, won't he?

Technique to Find Auxiliary

Look for helping verbs in the statement.

Example

She is reading.

Helping verb → is

Tag → isn't she?

IMPORTANT RULE

The auxiliary used in the statement must be repeated in the tag.

5A. COMPLETE AUXILIARY & HELPING VERBS TABLE

Type	Auxiliary Verb	Positive Example	Question Tag
Be Verb	am	I am ready,	aren't I?
Be Verb	is	She is happy,	isn't she?
Be Verb	are	They are students,	aren't they?
Be Verb	was	He was late,	wasn't he?
Be Verb	were	They were absent,	weren't they?
Have Verb	have	You have finished,	haven't you?
Have Verb	has	She has arrived,	hasn't she?
Have Verb	had	He had left,	hadn't he?
Do Verb	do	They do exercise,	don't they?
Do Verb	does	He does his work,	doesn't he?
Do Verb	did	She did the work,	didn't she?
Modal Verb	can	She can swim,	can't she?
Modal Verb	could	He could drive,	couldn't he?
Modal Verb	will	They will come,	won't they?
Modal Verb	would	You would help me,	wouldn't you?
Modal Verb	shall	We shall meet again,	shan't we?
Modal Verb	should	She should study,	shouldn't she?
Modal Verb	may	He may join us,	mayn't he? (rare/formal)
Modal Verb	might	They might win,	mightn't they?
Modal Verb	must	You must obey rules,	mustn't you?
Modal Verb	ought to	She ought to attend,	oughtn't she?
Modal Verb	need	He need work harder,	needn't he?
Modal Verb	dare	She dare speak,	daren't she?
Semi-modal	used to	He used to smoke,	didn't he?
Semi-modal	has to	She has to go,	doesn't she?

Semi-modal	had to	They had to leave,	didn't they?
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6. WHAT IF THERE IS NO AUXILIARY?

Use:

- do
- does
- did (according to tense.)

Examples

Statement	Tag
You like tea,	don't you?
He plays cricket,	doesn't he?
They went home,	didn't they?

MEMORY TRICK: "No Helping Verb → Use DO Family"

Present → do / does Past → did

7. NOUN → PRONOUN CHANGE IN QUESTION TAGS

In question tags, **nouns become pronouns.**

IMPORTANT RULE

Noun	Pronoun in Tag
Ravi	he
Lakshmi	she
The boys	they
The dog	it
Children	they

Examples

Statement	Question Tag
Ravi is a doctor,	isn't he?
Lakshmi can sing,	can't she?
The boys are playing,	aren't they?

MEMORY TRICK: "Tag uses pronouns, not nouns."

SPECIAL CASES

Subject	Pronoun Tag
Everyone	they
Someone	they
Nobody	they
This/That	it
These/Those	they

Examples

Statement	Tag
Everyone came,	didn't they?
Nobody called,	did they?
This is your bag,	isn't it?

8. CONTRACTIONS IN QUESTION TAGS

Question tags usually use contracted forms.

COMMON CONTRACTIONS

Full Form	Contracted Form
is not	isn't
are not	aren't
was not	wasn't
were not	weren't
do not	don't
does not	doesn't
did not	didn't
cannot	can't
will not	won't
should not	shouldn't
have not	haven't

Example

She is ready, isn't she?

NOT: ✗ is not she?

9. STEP-BY-STEP METHOD TO FORM QUESTION TAGS

STEP 1 – Identify Statement Type

Positive or Negative?

STEP 2 – Find Auxiliary Verb

Examples:

- is
- are
- have
- can
- will

STEP 3 – Change Positive ↔ Negative

Statement	Tag
Positive	Negative
Negative	Positive

STEP 4 – Convert Noun into Pronoun

Ravi → he

Lakshmi → she

STEP 5 – Add Question Mark

COMPLETE EXAMPLE

Statement: She is a teacher.

Step 1: Positive statement

Step 2: Auxiliary → is

Step 3: Negative form → isn't

Step 4: Pronoun → she

Final Answer: She is a teacher, isn't she?

10. QUESTION TAG RULES IN DETAIL

RULE 1

Positive Statement → Negative Tag

Example

You are busy, aren't you?

RULE 2

Negative Statement → Positive Tag

Example

She isn't ready, is she?

RULE 3

Auxiliary Must Match

Example

He can swim, can't he?

RULE 4**No Auxiliary → Use Do/Does/Did****Examples**

- She sings well, doesn't she?
- They played football, didn't they?

RULE 5**Pronoun Must Match Subject****Example**

Ravi is absent, isn't he?

RULE 6**Imperative Sentence → will you?****Examples**

- Open the window, will you?
- Don't shout, will you?

RULE 7**Let's → shall we?****Example:** Let's start now, shall we?**11. ODD & TRICKY QUESTION TAGS****(A) I am → aren't I?****Example:** I am late, aren't I?**Important TNTET Point**NOT:  amn't I?Correct:  aren't I?**(B) NEVER / HARDLY / SCARCELY / SELDOM**

These words are already negative. So, tag becomes positive.

Examples

Statement	Tag
He never lies,	does he?
She hardly speaks,	does she?
They scarcely know us,	do they?
She seldom visits us,	does she?

(C) EVERYONE / SOMEBODY / NOBODYUse: **they****Examples**

Statement	Tag
Everyone came,	didn't they?
Somebody called,	didn't they?
Nobody helped,	did they?

(D) THIS / THATUse: **it****Examples**

Statement	Tag
This is your pen,	isn't it?
That was funny,	wasn't it?

(E) THERE IS / THERE ARE

Repeat "there".

Examples

Statement	Tag
There is a problem,	isn't there?
There were many people,	weren't there?

(F) LET US vs LET'S

Sentence	Tag
Let's go,	shall we?
Let us go,	will you?

12. QUESTION TAG PATTERN TABLE

Statement Type	Tag Pattern
Positive	Negative Tag
Negative	Positive Tag
No auxiliary	do/does/did
Imperative	will you?
Let's	shall we?
I am	aren't I?
Everyone/Nobody	they
This/That	it

SUPER MEMORY FORMULA: "PANDA Rule"

P → Positive = Negative Tag

A → Auxiliary repeats

N → Negative = Positive Tag

D → Do/Does/Did if no auxiliary

A → Answer with Pronoun

13. MASTER PRACTICE TABLE

(A) POSITIVE STATEMENT → NEGATIVE TAG

Positive Statement	Negative Tag
She is a teacher,	isn't she?
They are ready,	aren't they?
He was absent,	wasn't he?
We were happy,	weren't we?
You have finished,	haven't you?
She has arrived,	hasn't she?
They had left,	hadn't they?
He plays football,	doesn't he?
They worked hard,	didn't they?
You can swim,	can't you?
She could dance,	couldn't she?
They will attend,	won't they?
He would help us,	wouldn't he?
We shall meet again,	shan't we?
You should obey rules,	shouldn't you?
She may join us,	mayn't she?
They might win,	mightn't they?
He must study,	mustn't he?
She ought to come,	oughtn't she?
I am late,	aren't I?

(B) NEGATIVE STATEMENT → POSITIVE TAG

Negative Statement	Positive Tag
She isn't a teacher,	is she?
They aren't ready,	are they?

He wasn't absent,	was he?
We weren't happy,	were we?
You haven't finished,	have you?
She hasn't arrived,	has she?
They hadn't left,	had they?
He doesn't play football,	does he?
They didn't work hard,	did they?
You can't swim,	can you?
She couldn't dance,	could she?
They won't attend,	will they?
He wouldn't help us,	would he?
We shan't meet again,	shall we?
You shouldn't disobey rules,	should you?
She may not join us,	may she?
They mightn't win,	might they?
He mustn't smoke,	must he?
She oughtn't to worry,	ought she?

(C) NEGATIVE WORDS → POSITIVE TAG

Statement	Positive Tag
He never lies,	does he?
She hardly speaks,	does she?
They seldom visit us,	do they?
Nobody called me,	did they?
Few students attended,	did they?
She rarely complains,	does she?

(D) IMPERATIVE SENTENCES

Imperative Sentence	Tag
Open the window,	will you?
Pass the salt,	will you?
Don't make noise,	will you?
Kindly help me,	would you?
Sit down,	won't you?

(E) LET'S SENTENCES

Statement	Tag
Let's start the lesson,	shall we?
Let's go outside,	shall we?
Let's help the poor,	shall we?

(F) SPECIAL PRONOUN CASES

Subject	Tag Pronoun	Example
Everyone	they	Everyone came, didn't they?
Somebody	they	Somebody called, didn't they?
Nobody	they	Nobody helped, did they?
This	it	This is yours, isn't it?
That	it	That was funny, wasn't it?
These	they	These are costly, aren't they?
Those	they	Those were beautiful, weren't they?

13B. QUICK IDENTIFICATION TABLE

Clue in Statement	Likely Tag Pattern
Positive sentence	Negative tag
Negative sentence	Positive tag
No auxiliary	do/does/did
"Let's"	shall we?

Imperative sentence	will you?
I am	aren't I?
never/hardly/seldom	Positive tag
Everyone/Nobody	they
This/That	it

14. COMMON ERRORS IN TNTET

Wrong	Correct
He is a doctor, is he?	He is a doctor, isn't he?
She plays tennis, plays she?	She plays tennis, doesn't she?
I am late, amn't I?	I am late, aren't I?
Let's go, will we?	Let's go, shall we?

15. TNTET MODEL QUESTIONS

Choose the correct question tag:

1. **She can drive, _____?**

- a) can she b) can't she c) does she d) doesn't she

✓ Answer: b) can't she

2. **Ravi went to school, _____?**

- a) didn't he b) did he c) wasn't he d) doesn't he

✓ Answer: a) didn't he

3. **Let's begin the class, _____?**

- a) will we b) shall we c) do we d) aren't we

✓ Answer: b) shall we

4. **Everyone attended the meeting, _____?**

- a) didn't he b) didn't they c) did he d) weren't they

✓ Answer: b) didn't they

5. **He never tells lies, _____?**

- a) doesn't he b) does he c) didn't he d) isn't he

✓ Answer: b) does he

6. **There is a problem, _____?**

- a) isn't it b) isn't there c) is there d) doesn't there

✓ Answer: b) isn't there

16. FINAL EXAM STRATEGY FOR TNTET

- Positive → Negative Tag
- Negative → Positive Tag
- Same Auxiliary repeats
- No Auxiliary → do/does/did
- Let's → shall we?

- Imperative → will you?
 - I am → aren't I?
 - Negative words → Positive Tag
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